

A close-up photograph of a large aircraft engine, showing the complex metal structure and rivets. A dark semi-transparent rectangular box is overlaid on the upper portion of the image, containing the text 'After 2000'.

After 2000

After more than 100 years of flight there are still new frontiers to explore. Planes such as the 787 Boeing Dreamliner, launched in 2009, are becoming ever more aerodynamically efficient and fuel efficient. Meanwhile, the military is increasingly moving away from expensive manned aircraft in favor of UCAVs (unmanned combat aerial vehicles) or drones. As NASA funding is cut, private entrepreneurs are taking up the torch, pushing the boundaries of wingborne flight and air-launch vehicles for traveling to the edge of space.